

Introduction

From the fact that you are reading this introduction it is fairly safe to assume that your life is going reasonably well. You have access to books, you have the linguistic and other capacities with which to read them, and you have the free time to do so. Such has not been true of the majority of people in human history.

But what do I mean by saying that your life is going reasonably well? The judgement I am making is about *well-being*, about how well lives go *for the person who lives them*. But you might wonder what well-being *is*. One thing I could do to try to help here is to point you to a string of synonyms ('welfare', 'prudential value', 'self-interest', 'utility') and you might find that somewhat helpful. But you might *still* be a little unsure or sceptical about the idea of someone's life going well or going badly. Let me say a little more.

Some people's lives go extremely well. They are born into happy families, they secure good educations, make friends, pursue interesting and rewarding work, enjoy pleasurable hobbies, have loving and supportive families. Other lives go extremely badly. Here is a description of such a life, a nineteenth-century English peasant's life:

His sire was a pauper, and his mother's milk wanted nourishment. From infancy his food has been bad as well as insufficient; and he now feels the pains of unsatisfied hunger nearly whenever he is awake. But half-clothed, and never supplied with more warmth than suffices to cook his scanty meals, cold and wet come to him, and stay by him with the weather. He is married, but he has not tasted the highest joys of husband and father. His partner, and little ones being, like himself, often hungry, seldom warm, sometimes sick without aid, and always sorrowful without hope, are greedy, selfish, and vexing; so, to use his own expression, he 'hates the sight of them', and resorts to his hovel, only because a hedge affords less shelter from the wind and rain. He must support his family, though he cannot do so. This brings begging, trickery, and quarrelling; and ends in settled craft. Though he have the inclination, he wants the courage to become, like more energetic men of his class, a poacher or smuggler on a large scale; but he pilfers occasionally, and teaches his children to lie and steal. His subdued and slavish manner toward his great neighbours shows that they treat him with suspicion and

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harshness. Consequently, he at once dreads and hates them; but he will never harm them by violent means. Too degraded to be desperate, he is thoroughly depraved. His miserable career will be short; rheumatism and asthma are conducting him to the workhouse, where he will breathe his last without one pleasant recollection, and so make room for another wretch who may live and die in the same way.¹

I hope you agree that the life described in this passage is going *badly* (within the period described, at the very least) and that features of the situations are extremely *bad for* the person within it. These evaluations concern the person's *well-being*. And they explain why the person is an apt object of pity rather than, say, envy, on account of how badly off they are.

Here is another way to get well-being in focus. Suppose that you have a medical condition that has contaminated your blood and that can be cured either by receiving a blood donation or by receiving a new kidney. As your friend I am compelled to help. It turns out that I am a compatible donor for both blood and kidney. Let us assume that you will be cured completely by either treatment (and the risk of failure is identical in each case). Now let us look at the two options. Donating my kidney is *much* more painful and much more time-consuming. It also has a much longer recovery period. Donating blood, by contrast, is only slightly painful, takes hardly any time, and leaves me with two kidneys.

Given these facts, it seems that we can conclude that each option is equally good *for you*. By contrast, donating my kidney is much more *costly* to me than simply donating my blood. It is worse *for me* to donate my kidney than to lose some blood.

The kind of value that we are thinking about when we try to determine whether the blood donation is better for me than the kidney donation is that of prudential value, of well-being, of how well my life goes for me. Another way to put the point is that the *currency* in which the blood donation is better for me than the kidney donation is the currency of my well-being.

Here is one final way to get well-being in focus. You are 25 and you now face a choice between two different careers. You could be in a band or you could be a researcher into fundamental physics (your talents are diverse!). To get around the issue of uncertainty, let us suppose that we have the full facts about what those two lives would be like (but your memory will be wiped after making the choice).

Suppose that the life in the band would be unbelievably *fun*. You would spend a lot of time playing music you love, you would spend time with your friends, you would see the world, attend all of the best parties, and visit exotic places. You would top the charts in every major country with your first album. However, despite once being extremely popular, your band would be a victim of changes in musical taste and so your career would be over at 40. Furthermore, the years of excess would take their toll and so you would experience five years of ill health before dying alone at 45.

By contrast, life as a research scientist would be extremely intellectually rewarding. You would spend a lot of time thinking about and researching issues that are fundamental to the nature of the universe and that you therefore find

extremely interesting. You would make discoveries about the fundamental nature of the universe, writing academic books whose influence, though modest, lasts for centuries. Your life would be comparatively solitary. You would have professional acquaintances with whom you are friendly but beyond your life partner and children you have few firm friends. However, your life would afford space for leisure time and for healthy habits and you would be active right up until your peaceful death at 70.

These two lives are very different and we can evaluate them in lots of different ways. But focusing exclusively on their prudential value, on how good they would be for the person who lives them, which would *you* rather live? If you have difficulty answering this question, this reflects the difficulty of comparing these lives when it comes to well-being or prudential value. It is hard to decide *how* good each of these lives would be for the person who lives them and, thus, which would be better for them to live. The difficulty you are facing is the difficulty of determining how well each life goes with respect to well-being.

Terminology

Let me say something about the terminology I will use in this book given that students, entirely reasonably, often find the range of terminology employed in discussions of well-being a little bewildering. I will sometimes simply talk about something being good (or bad) for someone. For example, ‘pleasure is good for me’, ‘pain is bad for me’. I will sometimes put points in terms of prudential value and disvalue. For example, ‘pleasure has prudential value’ and ‘pain has prudential disvalue’. I might also talk about what *enhances* well-being and what *detracts* from it. For example, ‘pleasure enhances well-being’ and ‘pain detracts from well-being’. Finally, I will sometimes talk about things benefitting or harming. For example, ‘pleasure benefits those who experience it’ and ‘pain harms those who experience it’. I will mostly treat these as mere stylistic variants.

Outline of the book

Overall structure

The first four chapters cover the most commonly discussed and most historically influential theories of well-being: hedonism, desire-fulfilment theories, objective list theories, and perfectionism. Chapters 5 and 6 cover two theories which are in some ways more recent additions to the suite of theories, theories which are for that reason less mapped out and understood. The first is the happiness theory of well-being, the other is the idea of hybrid theories of well-being. Chapter 7 is about a new topic – ill-being or what detracts from well-being or is bad for us. Chapters 8 covers views about the relationship between the well-being we have at points in our lives and the overall goodness of our lives. Chapter 9 takes up the question of whether death is a harm to us.

Chapter summary

In the first chapter we examine hedonism about well-being. Roughly, the view claims that only pleasure is ultimately good for us and that only pain is ultimately bad for us. Such a theory has a lot going for it. Many cases of pleasure seem obviously to be good for us. And many cases of pain seem obviously to be bad for us. Nonetheless, hedonism faces a significant set of challenges, challenges that suggest that pleasure and pain alone are not the only things that are good and bad for us.

In Chapter 2, we move on to discuss desire-fulfilment theories of well-being, theories that claim that what is good for us is what fulfils our desires (and that what is bad for us is what frustrates them). It seems intuitively very plausible that getting what we want is good for us and that failing to get what we want is bad for us. But such theories face challenges. In their most basic form they seem to generate implausible results. This motivates further development and refinement of the theory.

Chapter 3 examines objective list theories of well-being, theories that claim that things are good or bad for people independently of their desiring them or being averse to them. As we shall see, such theories have certain virtues but face important challenges. These include the claim that such theories are arbitrary or problematically alienating. This objection is discussed in the chapter. Then, in an appendix to Chapter 3, I revisit the alienation objection to objective list theories and try to show a range of different ways in which one could interpret the idea that a theory of well-being can be alienating.

In Chapter 4 we examine the credentials of ‘perfectionist’ theories of well-being. These theories postulate a significant connection between (i) what is good for humans and (ii) human nature (and so on for other kinds of animals).

In Chapters 5 and 6 we examine two alternate theories of well-being. The first, the happiness theory of well-being, claims that happiness (alone) contributes to well-being. A major part of assessing this theory consists of looking at different theories of the nature of happiness. For that reason we spend some time examining theories of the nature of happiness.

Chapter 6 is the final chapter dealing with theories of well-being. Therein we look at a very recent development: hybrid theories of well-being. Such theories try to combine two theories to generate more complex, but hopefully more plausible, theories of well-being. Whether such theories offer much promise of improving upon their constituent parts is a major question addressed by that chapter.

In Chapter 7 we take up a relatively new area of inquiry: ill-being, or what is non-instrumentally bad for us. In the chapter we see that theories of well-being vary quite widely in how easily they can be extended to cover what is bad for us, as well as what is good for us.

In Chapter 8 we move away from looking at particular things that are good/bad for people (and why) or the prudential value of particular episodes and look instead at the prudential value of *lives* as a whole. In particular, we examine whether a person’s lifetime well-being (how their life goes in terms of well-being as a whole) is determined in a simple additive fashion by how it goes at each point. Our focus is on something called the ‘shape of a life hypothesis’, which rejects the simple addition model of lifetime well-being.

Finally, in Chapter 9 we move on to thinking about well-being and the end of life. In particular, whether death harms us. As we see in that chapter, it is necessary to make clear exactly what the question is. There are many different ways to interpret the claim that death is a harm and various arguments only target specific versions of the claim.

How this book is written

A large proportion of this book arose from undergraduate teaching. In that teaching I found it surprisingly difficult to (i) examine the particular theories and claims offered by philosophers of well-being whilst also (ii) guiding the students to understand the relevant issues and how to *theorise* about well-being. Some of this difficulty is terminological. Some of it stems from differences in the theoretical or historical contexts of the discussions.

Subsequently my lectures on well-being gradually evolved to a point where I introduce the theories and issues myself and then direct students to the relevant works of other philosophers. I largely preserve that style here. I think it is better that readers go away with a sense of what the relevant issues are and what the theories are like *in general* rather than focusing, from the outset, on their detailed development by particular philosophers. I explain the choice of style knowing that it might otherwise be misconstrued as the product of overconfidence. The truth is the exact opposite.

I have aimed to make this text non-partisan but I have not aimed simply for straightforward comparative description. It would be underwhelming, I think, if the dialectic of the book was simply comparative: ‘X argues p, q, r’, ‘Y argues a, b, c’. I also think that *critical* discussion of the theories better equips students to *theorise* about well-being rather than to simply know what the different views hold. Whilst I do not try to settle what the truth about well-being is, I allow myself to argue and to claim that some theories have virtues and vices, that some objections are good, and that some others do not work. But the reader must remain critical as they go along.

Finally, I have written the chapters to be as standalone as possible. This comes at the cost of occasional repetition of material but I have kept this to a minimum. There are themes running through the chapters which mean that one will often get more out of reading a later chapter if one has read the earlier ones but each chapter should be fully clear by itself.

Note

I Attributed to ‘A Liberal Member of Parliament (1830)’ by Engels (1845).

Reference

Engels, F. (1845). ‘The Condition of the Working Class in England’. <https://www.marxists.org/archive/marx/works/1845/condition-working-class/ch12.htm>, accessed 22 December 2015.